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REL 101: Introduction to the Study of Religion

Describe religious traditions accurately before you evaluate them

FACULTY PRIMER

Faculty Primer

Faculty of Arts
Religion & Human Relations | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

This pack introduces the academic study of religion: key terms, the major traditions present in Nigeria, African Traditional Religion without caricature, and the method of describing before evaluating. It also covers the ethics of studying living communities.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Define religion, belief, ritual and sacred with reference to scholars.
- Compare Christianity, Islam and African Traditional Religion accurately.
- Apply the describe-then-analyse method.
- Follow ethical norms in fieldwork with religious communities.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Terms that need defining

Definitions shape what you notice.

- Religion: a contested category; substantive and functional definitions differ.
- Belief, practice, community and institution as four dimensions.
- Sacred and profane; purity, taboo and boundary.
- Ritual: repetitive, patterned action with symbolic meaning.
- Myth: a foundational narrative, not a synonym for falsehood.
- Syncretism, conversion and revival as processes, not labels.

Traditions in Nigeria

Accuracy beats generalisation.

- Christianity: denominational diversity, Pentecostal growth and independent churches.
- Islam: Maliki jurisprudence in the north, Sufi orders, reform movements.
- African Traditional Religion: a misleading singular term for diverse traditions with shared features - divination, ancestors, deities, community rites.
- Interreligious relations and conflict, and the role of the state.
- Internal diversity within every tradition; avoid treating one expression as the whole.
- Use the names communities use for themselves.

> **Describe, then evaluate**
> Describe a practice in the terms its practitioners use, then analyse it with your academic tools. Reversing the order produces caricature.

Method and ethics

Religion is studied, not proselytised.

- Bracketing: set aside your own commitments for the purposes of description.
- Use insider and outsider accounts together.
- Obtain consent before interviews and photography.
- Anonymise where disclosure could expose or endanger participants.
- Distinguish normative theology from descriptive religious studies.
- Cite sources with their tradition and date.

Studying religion without adjudicating it

Religious studies examines beliefs, practices and institutions as human phenomena. It does not require the student to accept or reject any tradition's truth claims; it requires the student to describe them accurately, explain them in context and analyse their effects. This methodological neutrality is often called bracketing, and it is a discipline, not indifference.

The field uses several approaches. Phenomenological description tries to capture how a practice appears to its practitioners. Historical analysis traces origins and change. Sociological analysis asks what religion does for and to a society. Anthropological work examines ritual, kinship and symbolism. Comparative study looks for patterns across traditions while resisting the temptation to flatten differences.

The commonest student error is apologetics in either direction - defending or attacking a tradition instead of analysing it. If your paragraph could be preached, it is not yet an academic paragraph.

Belief, practice and institution

Traditions are not only doctrines. They are calendars, diets, dress, architecture, music, lifecycle rituals, authority structures and money. A student who studies only scripture has studied one dimension of a three-dimensional object.

Ritual is a central analytic category. Most definitions include a prescribed sequence, a symbolic dimension, a participant body and a marked separation from ordinary time. Rites of passage commonly follow a pattern of separation, liminality and incorporation; this framework is useful for analysing naming ceremonies, weddings, initiations and funerals across traditions.

Authority takes different forms: textual (interpretation of scripture), charismatic (personal gift), institutional (office and hierarchy) and customary (elders and lineage). Conflicts within traditions are frequently conflicts about which authority governs.

> **Describe before you explain**
> First say what practitioners do and say in their own terms. Then explain it. Skipping the first step produces explanation that is really projection.

Religion in Nigeria: plurality and proximity

Nigeria is a country of extraordinary religious plurality: Islam in its various schools, Christianity in many denominations, and indigenous traditions that continue in practices often described as "customary" even by their practitioners. These traditions have coexisted, borrowed from and competed with one another for centuries.

The categories are not clean. Many Christians and Muslims participate in practices rooted in indigenous tradition; naming ceremonies, burial rites and festivals often combine elements. Scholars describe this as syncretism, parallel practice or lived religion, depending on the degree of integration.

Religion in Nigeria is also inseparable from politics, education, media and economy. Religious institutions run schools and hospitals, shape electoral behaviour, and provide welfare where the state does not. Analysis that treats religion as private belief misses most of what it does publicly.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. Analysing a naming ceremony

You must describe and analyse a naming ceremony in 500 words without evaluating it.

1. Describe the sequence: who is present, what is said, what objects are used, when it happens.
2. Identify the symbolic elements and the meanings participants give them.
3. Apply a rite-of-passage frame: what is the child separated from, what liminal state, what incorporation?
4. Identify authority: who performs, who witnesses, who names.
5. Explain social functions: kinship recognition, legitimacy, community obligation.
6. Note change: urban versions, smaller gatherings, religious mixing.

> **What to carry forward**
> Description, symbol, structure, authority, function, change. Six moves, one page.

2. Answering a question about religious conflict carefully

You are asked why religious conflict occurs in Nigeria. Avoid both apologetics and crude causal claims.

1. Distinguish religious from religiously framed conflict.
2. Identify material factors: land, grazing routes, employment, political competition.
3. Identify the role of religious language and institutions in mobilising.
4. Note the role of media and rumour in escalation.
5. Give one well-documented case and cite it.
6. Conclude that religion is often a vocabulary for conflict with other causes, without denying that belief can itself motivate action.

> **What to carry forward**
> Avoid single-cause explanations. Name the mechanisms.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. What does methodological neutrality require of a student of religion, and what does it not require?

15 marks

1. Define bracketing of truth claims.
2. Distinguish neutrality from indifference and from relativism.
3. Show what it demands: accurate description, fair use of sources, no preaching.
4. Show what it does not demand: abandoning judgement about evidence or ethics.

Q2. Explain the three phases of a rite of passage and apply them to one Nigerian ceremony.

15 marks

1. Separation, liminality, incorporation.
2. Describe the ceremony's sequence in those terms.
3. Identify symbols marking each phase.
4. Explain the social function of the liminal phase.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Bracketing. Setting aside judgement on truth claims in order to describe and analyse.

Phenomenology of religion. An approach describing religious experience and practice as it appears to participants.

Ritual. A prescribed symbolic sequence performed in a marked setting and time.

Rite of passage. A ceremony marking transition between social states through separation, liminality and incorporation.

Liminality. The in-between phase of a rite of passage where normal status is suspended.

Syncretism. The blending of elements from different religious traditions.

Lived religion. Religion as practised in everyday life rather than as official doctrine.

Charismatic authority. Authority deriving from perceived personal gift rather than office.

Sacred. That which a community sets apart as powerful and non-ordinary.

Cosmology. A community's account of the structure of the world and its powers.

Comparative religion. The study of patterns and differences across traditions.

Apologetics. Argument in defence of a tradition's truth, as distinct from analysis of it.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - Method

Bracketing.

- Rewrite one preaching paragraph as analysis.
- List the approaches and their questions.
- Define neutral description.

Week 2 - Practice

Ritual.

- Observe a ceremony with permission.
- Write a descriptive account.
- Apply the rite-of-passage frame.

Week 3 - Plurality

Nigeria.

- Map three traditions in your locality.
- Document one instance of mixing.
- Interview one practitioner.

Week 4 - Analysis

Essay.

- Write a 15-mark answer.
- Remove every evaluative claim.
- Cite two academic sources.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- Any introduction to religious studies covering method, ritual and typology.
- An ethnography of religious practice in Nigeria.
- Scholarship on religious plurality and conflict in northern and central Nigeria.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Why is 'African Traditional Religion' a contested singular term?

Answer: It groups diverse, locally distinct traditions under one label, obscuring their differences and histories.

2. What does bracketing mean in the study of religion?

Answer: Setting aside one's own commitments temporarily in order to describe a tradition accurately on its own terms.

3. Give two dimensions of religion besides belief.

Answer: Practice and community; institution and ritual are further dimensions.

4. Distinguish theology from religious studies.

Answer: Theology argues from within a tradition; religious studies describes and analyses traditions as an academic field.

5. Name one fieldwork ethics requirement.

Answer: Informed consent before interviews or photography, plus protection of participant confidentiality.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Write two definitions of religion from different scholars.
- [ ] Compare three traditions across four dimensions.
- [ ] Learn ten terms with examples.
- [ ] Visit a service or site with permission and take descriptive notes.
- [ ] Write a description with no evaluative language.
- [ ] Then write a separate analytical section.
- [ ] Check every claim against a cited source.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

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